
Understanding and Strengthening the Self

Introduction: The Lifelong Task of Knowing Oneself

Every individual, at some point, asks fundamental questions: *Who am I? What am I capable of? What do I want to become?* These questions are not merely philosophical exercises. They are practical concerns that shape decision-making, career choices, relationships, and overall well-being.

Understanding the self is not a single event but a lifelong process. From childhood through late adulthood, individuals undergo continuous development — physically, cognitively, and socially. Each stage of life presents unique challenges and opportunities for growth. How a person navigates these stages determines not only their career trajectory but also their sense of purpose, fulfillment, and identity.

This reading material examines two major developmental theories: **Erik Erikson's Psychosocial Theory**, which emphasizes how social relationships shape identity across eight stages of life, and **Donald Super's Career Development Theory**, which describes how career choices and adaptations evolve as individuals mature. By understanding these frameworks, learners can better understand their own developmental journey and make informed decisions about their future.

Part 1: Erik Erikson's Psychosocial Theory of Development

Erik Erikson (1902–1994) proposed a lifespan model of development that emphasizes how social relationships shape the sense of self. Unlike theories that focus primarily on childhood, Erikson's model spans the entire human lifespan, from infancy to late adulthood.

Erikson suggested that individuals pass through **eight stages**, each marked by a central conflict, or **psychosocial crisis**, that must be resolved for healthy personality development. Successful resolution of each crisis leads to the development of a fundamental virtue or strength. Unsuccessful resolution can result in difficulties in later stages.

The Eight Stages of Psychosocial Development

Stage	Age Range	Psychosocial Crisis	Successful Resolution	Unsuccessful Resolution
1. Infancy	Birth to 18 mos.	Trust vs. Mistrust	Develops trust in caregivers and the world	Develops fear and suspicion of others
2. Early Childhood	2 to 3 years	Autonomy vs. Shame/Doubt	Develops a sense of personal control and independence	Develops self-doubt and shame about abilities
3. Preschool	3 to 5 years	Initiative vs. Guilt	Learns to initiate activities and lead others	Feels guilty about attempts to take initiative
4. School Age	6 to 11 years	Industry vs. Inferiority	Develops competence and pride in accomplishments	Feels inferior and doubts abilities
5. Adolescence	12 to 18 years	Identity vs. Role Confusion	Develops a strong sense of personal identity	Experiences confusion about roles and identity

Stage	Age Range	Psychosocial Crisis	Successful Resolution	Unsuccessful Resolution
6. Young Adulthood	19 to 40 years	Intimacy vs. Isolation	Forms close, committed relationships	Experiences loneliness and emotional isolation
7. Middle Adulthood	40 to 65 years	Generativity vs. Stagnation	Contributes to society and guides the next generation	Feels unproductive and disconnected from others
8. Late Adulthood	65 years and older	Integrity vs. Despair	Looks back on life with satisfaction and fulfillment	Feels regret and bitterness about missed opportunities

Focus on Adolescence: Identity vs. Role Confusion

For senior high school students, the fifth stage — **Identity vs. Role Confusion** — is particularly relevant. During adolescence, individuals explore different roles, beliefs, and career possibilities. They ask: *What kind of person do I want to be? What do I believe? What am I good at?*

Signs of healthy identity formation:

- Exploring different interests and career options
- Developing a personal set of values and beliefs
- Forming a coherent sense of self across different social contexts
- Making commitments to goals, relationships, and ideologies

Signs of role confusion:

- Feeling uncertain about one's place in the world
- Shifting frequently between different personas or interests without commitment
- Difficulty making decisions about the future
- Feeling pressure to conform to others' expectations without personal conviction

Why this matters: Failure to establish a clear identity during adolescence can lead to role confusion, where individuals remain uncertain about who they are and what they want from life. Successful identity formation, by contrast, provides a foundation for the next stage: developing intimate relationships in young adulthood.

Part 2: Donald Super's Career Development Theory

While Erikson focused on overall psychosocial development, Donald Super (1910–1994) proposed a **life-span, life-space theory** specifically focused on career development. Super recognized that career choices are not single events but a lifelong process of adaptation.

The Five Stages of Career Development

Stage	Typical Age	Characteristics	Key Tasks
Growth	Birth to 14	Development of self-concept, attitudes, and general understanding of the world of work	Developing a realistic self-concept; learning to relate to others; accepting one's own limitations

Exploration	15 to 24	"Trying out" through classes, work, and hobbies; tentative career choices	Learning about opportunities; finding desired opportunities; identifying new tasks to explore
Establishment	25 to 44	Entry-level skill building and stabilization through work experience	Getting started in a chosen field; settling into a suitable position; developing new skills
Maintenance	45 to 64	Continual adjustment to improve position; holding one's own against competition	Verifying occupational choice; making position secure; keeping what one enjoys
Decline	65 and older	Reduced output; preparation for retirement	Reducing working hours; focusing on essentials; developing non-occupational roles

Focus on the Exploration Stage (Ages 15–24)

For senior high school students, the **Exploration Stage** is directly relevant. During this period, individuals:

- Experiment with different roles through classes, extracurricular activities, and part-time work
- Make tentative career choices that may be refined or changed over time
- Develop skills through education and hobby-based experiences
- Learn about occupational opportunities through research, interviews, and exposure

Key insight from Super's theory: Career choices are not permanent decisions made once and never revisited. They evolve as individuals gain experience, develop new skills, and refine their self-concept. Tentative choices made during adolescence provide direction, but they can and should be adjusted as new information becomes available.

Part 3: Applying Developmental Theories — The Case of Hidilyn Diaz

The following case study illustrates how Super's Career Development Theory applies to a real-life success story.

Hidilyn Diaz's Journey

Hidilyn Diaz's journey as an Olympic gold medalist can be meaningfully analyzed through Donald Super's Career Development Theory.

Growth Stage (Birth to 14): Growing up in Zamboanga, Diaz developed an awareness of her interests and capabilities. She was introduced to weightlifting by a cousin, sparking an early interest in the sport. During this stage, she developed fundamental self-concept and attitudes toward achievement.

Exploration Stage (15–24): As a teenager, Diaz entered the exploration stage, experimenting with her athletic skills and competing in local and national events. Her participation in the 2008 Beijing Olympics at age 17 signaled her active exploration of a professional athletic career. She tried out her abilities on an international stage, gaining valuable experience. During this period, she also competed in the 2012 London Olympics, refining her skills and learning from each competition.

Establishment Stage (25–44): Diaz entered the establishment stage in her mid-20s. She gained significant recognition through her silver medal in the 2016 Rio Olympics, marking her transition into a stable, high-level competitive career. The pinnacle of this stage came with her gold medal victory in the 2020 Tokyo Olympics (held in 2021), where she became the first Filipino Olympic gold medalist. At 35 years old (2026), Diaz remains firmly within the establishment stage, continuing to compete at elite levels while solidifying her identity as a professional athlete and national icon.

Future Stages (45 and beyond): Diaz has not yet entered the maintenance stage, as she continues to compete actively. However, developmental theory suggests that as she approaches her mid-40s, she may gradually transition into the maintenance stage, where the focus shifts from peak achievement to sustaining position and mentoring younger athletes. The decline stage remains distant, typically beginning after age 65,

when athletes may reduce competitive participation and transition fully into coaching, advocacy, speaking, or community leadership roles.

Key Factors Contributing to Diaz's Success

Factor	Explanation
Self-concept clarity	Diaz developed a clear understanding of her strengths and commitment to weightlifting
Support system	Family, coaches, and mentors provided guidance through each developmental stage
Resilience	She overcame setbacks, including initial losses, to continue progressing
Adaptability	She adjusted her training, techniques, and goals as she moved through career stages
Purpose beyond self	Her success became tied to national pride, motivating continued effort

Part 4: Navigating Challenges in Adolescence

Adolescence presents unique challenges that require self-awareness, decision-making skills, and sometimes the courage to resist peer pressure. The following scenarios illustrate common dilemmas faced by individuals in the exploration stage.

Scenario 1: Peer Pressure and Illegal Substances

Situation: Marco is invited to a party. His friends offer him expensive designer drugs that are illegal.

Factors to consider:

- Immediate consequences (legal, health, safety)
- Long-term impact on goals and aspirations
- The influence of peer pressure versus personal values
- Alternative ways to maintain friendships without compromising values

Developmental perspective: During adolescence, peer influence is particularly strong. However, the ability to make independent decisions aligned with personal values is a marker of healthy identity formation.

Suggested approach: Marco could assert his boundaries clearly: *"I appreciate the offer, but I am not interested. I have goals that this would jeopardize."* He may also consider whether these friends respect his values or pressure him to conform.

Scenario 2: Relationship Decisions and Boundaries

Situation: Joey, who has been dating his significant other for four years, finds the relationship boring and wants to explore sexual relations despite prioritizing studies and college admission.

Factors to consider:

- Emotional readiness and mutual consent
- Potential consequences (emotional, physical, social)
- Whether sexual activity would genuinely address boredom or merely complicate the situation
- The partner's feelings and boundaries

Developmental perspective: Adolescence and young adulthood involve learning to form intimate relationships. Healthy intimacy requires communication, respect for boundaries, and mutual decision-making — not pressure or coercion.

Suggested approach: Joey should communicate openly with his partner rather than making assumptions. If boredom is the issue, exploring new activities or conversations together may be more appropriate than escalating physical intimacy.

Scenario 3: Academic Setbacks and Resilience

Situation: Madel fails the entrance examination for her dream university despite hard preparation. She feels hopeless and does not want to study anymore.

Factors to consider:

- Alternative educational pathways (other universities, second semesters, transfer options)
- Whether one examination defines future success
- The role of resilience in long-term achievement

Developmental perspective: Setbacks are normal in any developmental trajectory. How individuals respond to failure — whether with despair or renewed effort — shapes their future success.

Suggested approach: Madel could explore other universities offering similar programs, consider transferring after one semester, or take a gap year to strengthen her application. A supportive friend might write: *"This setback does not define you. You prepared hard, and that effort will serve you well wherever you study. Take time to grieve, then explore your options."*

Part 5: Understanding Personal Identity

Identity formation involves integrating various aspects of the self into a coherent whole.

Dimensions of Personal Identity

Dimension	Questions to Consider
Values	What principles matter most? (Honesty, kindness, achievement, family, faith)
Strengths	What activities come naturally? What do others recognize as talents?

Dimension	Questions to Consider
Interests	What topics or activities generate genuine curiosity and engagement?
Aspirations	What kind of life, career, and relationships are desirable?
Beliefs	What assumptions about the world, others, and oneself guide decisions?
Relationships	What roles do family, friends, mentors, and community play in one's life?

Identity Exploration Prompts

For personal reflection or journaling:

1. *"Who am I, separate from others' expectations?"*
2. *"What are my three greatest strengths, and how do I know?"*
3. *"What values are non-negotiable in my life?"*
4. *"What do I want to be doing five years from now? Ten years?"*
5. *"What obstacles have I overcome, and what did they teach me?"*

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Psychosocial Crisis	A central conflict at each stage of Erikson's theory that must be resolved for healthy development
Identity vs. Role Confusion	The psychosocial crisis of adolescence; developing a coherent sense of self versus remaining uncertain about one's identity
Generativity	The concern for establishing and guiding the next generation; the central task of middle adulthood
Integrity vs. Despair	The psychosocial crisis of late adulthood; looking back on life with satisfaction versus regret
Life-Span Approach	Recognition that development and career choices continue across the entire lifetime, not just in childhood
Exploration Stage	In Super's theory, the period (ages 15–24) of trying out different roles and making tentative career choices
Self-Concept	An individual's perception of their own abilities, values, and identity

Review Questions

Responses should be written on a separate sheet of paper.

1. According to Erikson, what is the primary psychosocial task of adolescence? Describe what successful resolution of this crisis looks like.
2. A 16-year-old student is unsure about future career paths, shifting interests frequently, and feeling pressured by parents' expectations. Which of Erikson's stages does this reflect, and what advice would you give based on developmental theory?
3. Using Super's Career Development Theory, identify which stage a 17-year-old senior high school student is in. What are the key tasks of this stage?
4. Hidilyn Diaz's career path illustrates Super's five stages. Identify which stage corresponds to her Olympic gold medal win and explain why.
5. A classmate fails an important examination and declares, "*I am a failure. I will never succeed at anything.*" How would understanding Erikson's concept of identity formation help you respond to this classmate?